SPORTING SPIRIT

*BADMINTON PLAYER **ASHWINI PONNAPPA, 34,** IS OFF TO HER THIRD OLYMPICS, THIS TIME WITH A NEW PARTNER, TANISHA CRASTO*

In January last year, Ashwini Ponnappa played her first tournament alongside new partner, Tanisha Crasto. Their 14-year age difference made all the news, as did Ponnappa's return to women's doubles after a prolonged break. "I had people come up to me a few times to ask if I've retired. And this was at a time I was actively training and competing. It was a bit sad to hear it but yes, it feels great to finally be out of the 'retirement phase'," says Ponnappa, 34, laughing.

What many considered to be an unlikely pairing will now be going to the Paris Olympics in July. Their start was slow, yet steady. In June 2023, when they won the Nantes International Challenge, they were still travelling on their own and discovering their potential on court. By year-end, they had made five finals and won three of them.

It helped them gather enough points to qualify for bigger tournaments and, in turn, face tougher opponents and longer rallies. At the Malaysia Open in January, they beat former world champions Mayu Matsumoto and Wakana Nagahara. What also pushed them was the presence of compatriots Treesa Jolly and Gayatri Gopichand, who were also in the race for the Olympics. "It kept us on our toes as this was the first time two Indian pairs were competing," says Ponnappa.

Starting March 5, they took on the rigour of playing five tournaments in as many weeks, looking to make deep runs and gather important points for qualification. At the Swiss Open, Ponnappa hurt her ankle and had to play through the pain. Far more intense was the mental exhaustion. "A lot of us were in the same boat trying to manage the body. You have to simply learn to push through. Those were not just tournaments. Every win mattered, especially towards the end of the Olympic qualifying period," she says.

This will be Ponnappa's third Olympics, for Crasto, it'll be her debut. They have three more tournaments coming up in the next few weeks, which they'll use to hone their game further. And then it's the Games, and proving the naysayers wrong. ■

–Shail Desai

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